# the epistemology of photography

Elliot Krasnopoler, PhD

# what is epistemology?

# today's plan

- the earliest promises of photography

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- photography beyond human sight

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- images as instruments of the state

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- documentary and manipulation

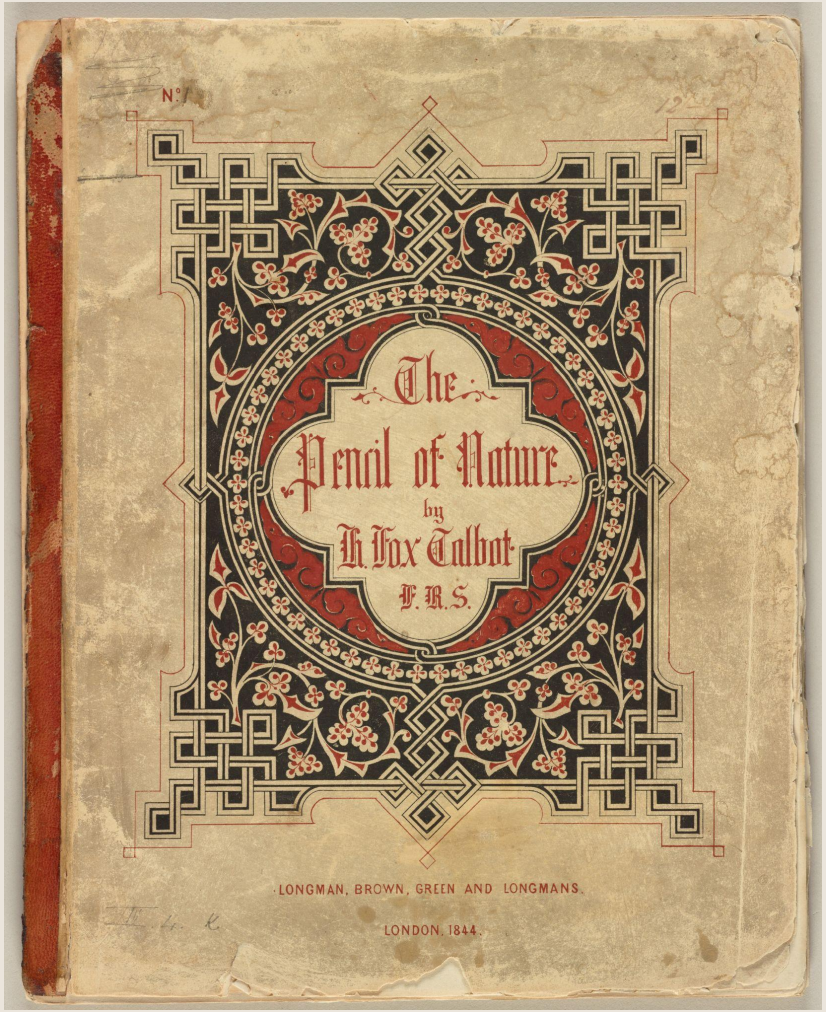
# today's plan

- the earliest promises of photography
- photography beyond human sight
- images as instruments of the state
- documentary and manipulation
- images beyond referents

# section i.

*the earliest promises of photography*

**William Henry Fox Talbot**
*The Roofline of Lacock Abbey*
1835–39




**William Henry Fox Talbot**
*The Pencil of Nature* (title page)
1844

**William Henry Fox Talbot**
*Plate III: Articles of China*
1844

"...the whole cabinet of a Virtuoso and collector of old China might be depicted on paper in little more time than it would take him to make a written inventory describing it in the usual way. The more strange and fantastic the forms of his old teapots, the more advantage in having their pictures given instead of their descriptions.

And should a thief afterwards purloin the treasures—if the mute testimony of the picture were to be produced against him in court—it would certainly be evidence of a novel kind; but what the judge and jury might say to it, is a matter which I leave to the speculation of those who possess legal acumen."

**William Henry Fox Talbot**
*Plate XIII: Queen's College*
1844

"...the operator himself discovers on examination, perhaps long afterwards, that he has depicted many things he had no notion of at the time. Sometimes inscriptions and dates are found upon the buildings, or printed placards most irrelevant, are discovered upon their walls: sometimes a distant dial-plate is seen, and upon it—unconsciously recorded—the hour of the day at which the view was taken"

**William Henry Fox Talbot**
*Plate XIII: Queen's College*
1844

# the index

**Victor Burgin**
*Photopath*
1967-69
Fruitmarket Gallery,
1984

A PATH ALONG THE FLOOR, OF PROPORTIONS 1X21 UNITS, PHOTOGRAPHED. PHOTOGRAPHS PRINTED TO ACTUAL SIZE OF OBJECTS AND PRINTS ATTACHED TO FLOOR SO THAT IMAGES ARE PERFECTLY CONGRUENT WITH THEIR OBJECTS.

**Victor Burgin**
*Photopath*
1967-69

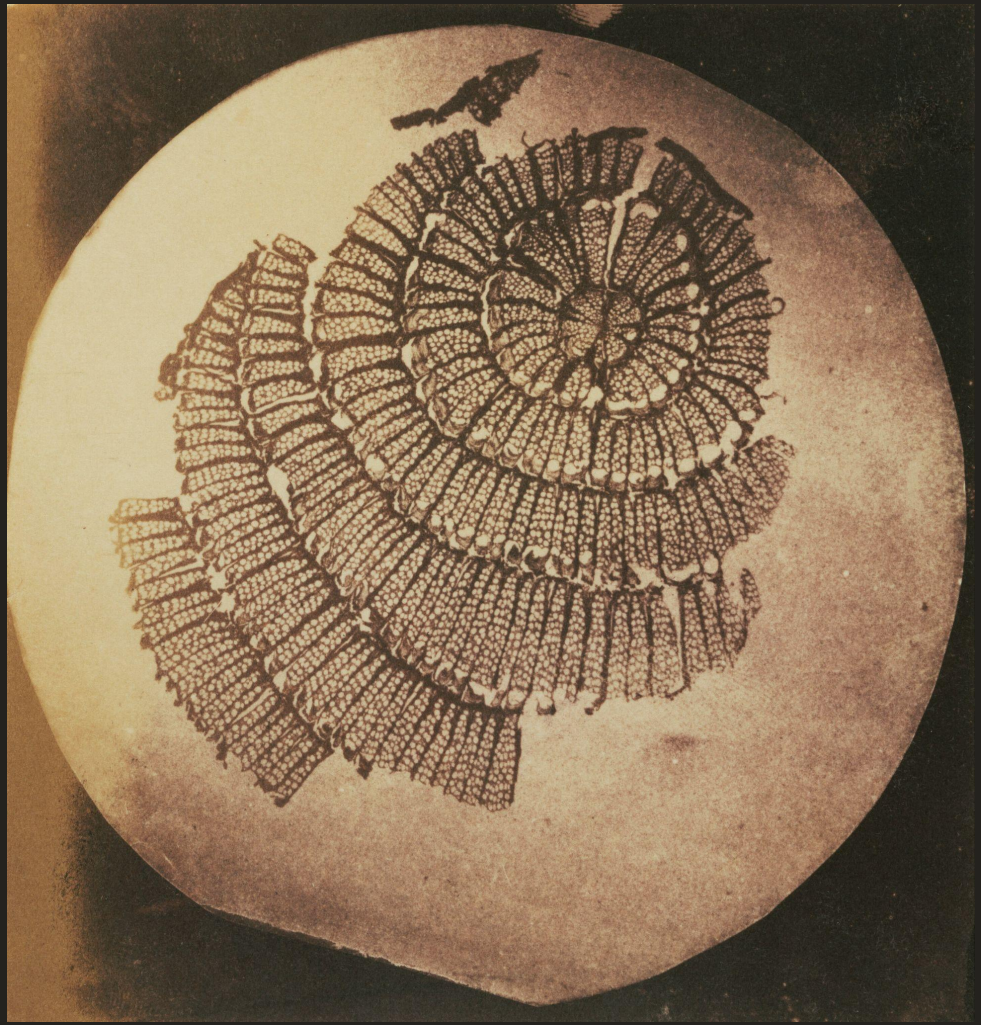
**Victor Burgin**
*Photopath*
1967-69
Cristin Tierney
Gallery, 2023

# key points

- drawn by light rather than human touch
- captures beyond the maker’s intention
- photography is a new kind of evidence
- photographs are indexical and iconic

# section ii.

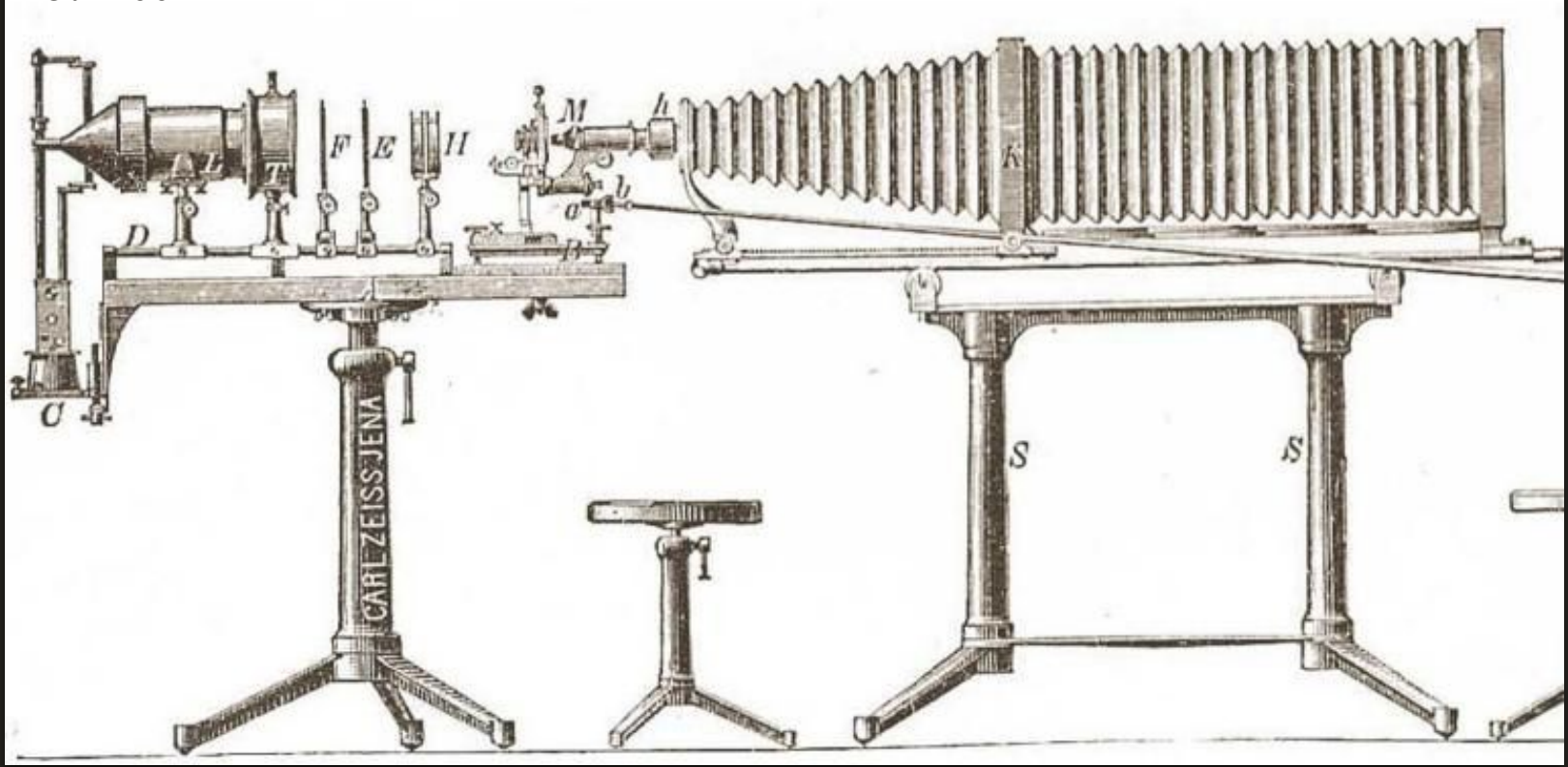
*photography beyond human sight*



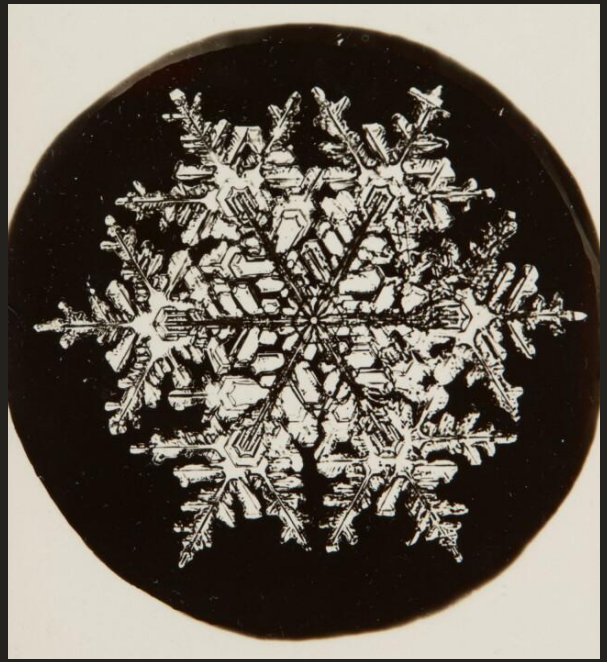
**Henry Fox Talbot**
*Photomicrograph of plant stem*
1840s

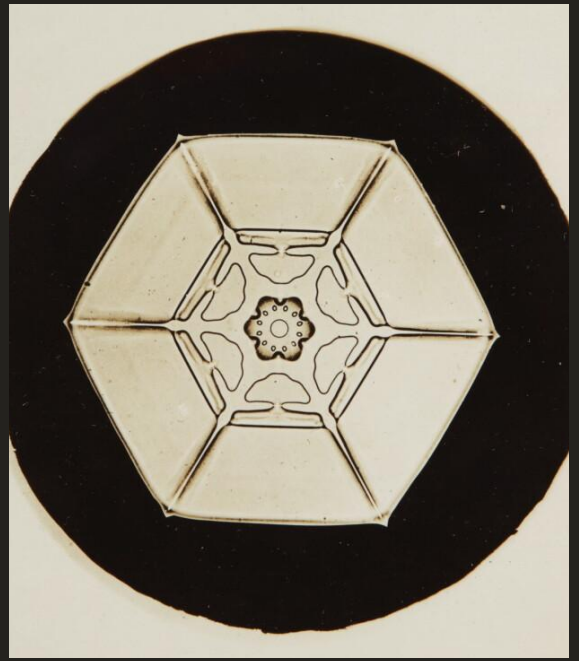
**Photomicrograph equipment**

c. 1887



**Arthur E. Durham**
*Photomicrograph of a flea*
1863 or 1864





**Wilson A. Bentley**
*Snowflakes*
c. 1885-1920s

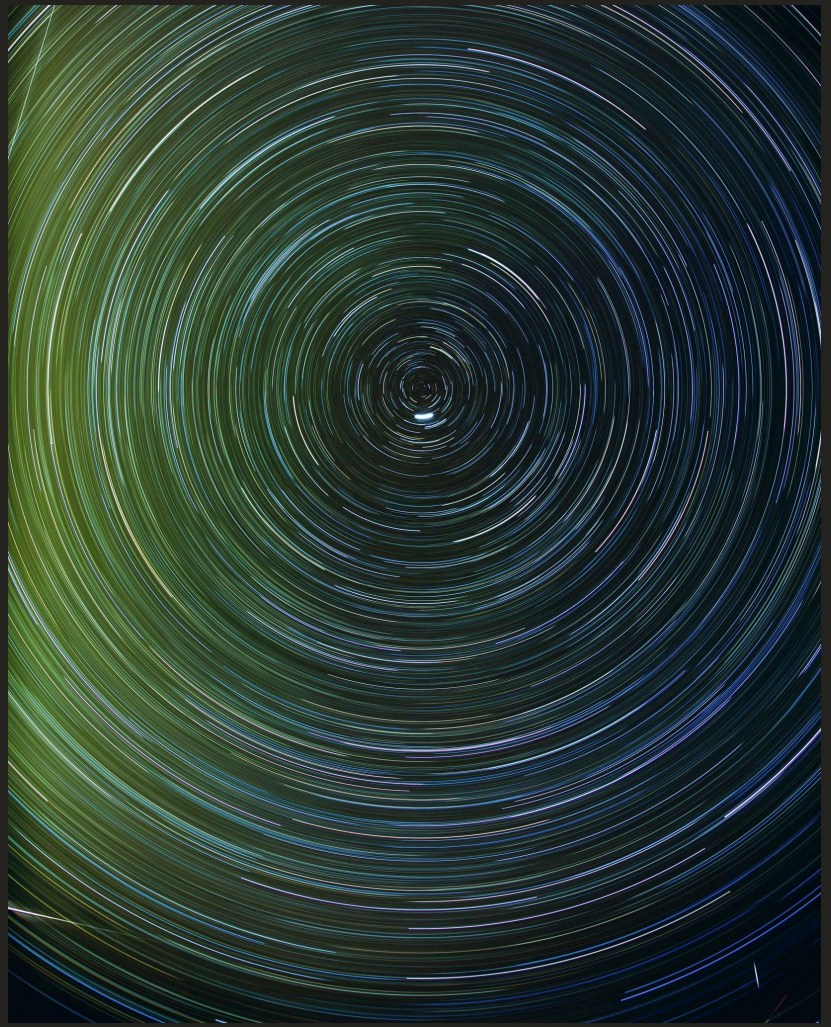
**John Adams Whipple**
*View of the Moon*
1852

**Henry Draper**
*Moon, 10 Second Exposure*
1872

**Henry Draper**
*Moon, 10 Second Exposure*
(detail)
1872

# astrological photography and contemporary art

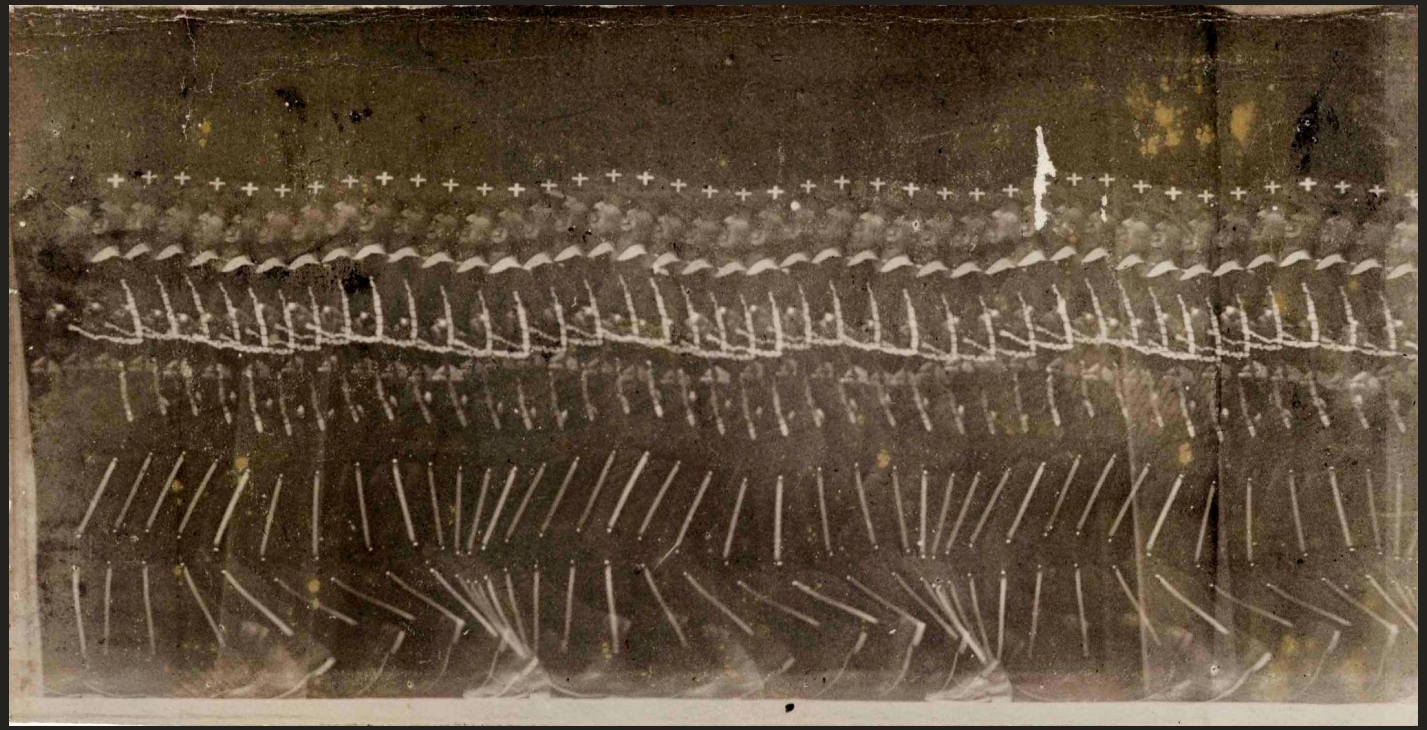
**Trevor Paglen**
*UNKNOWN #82139 (Unclassified object in the Sadr Region)*
2023



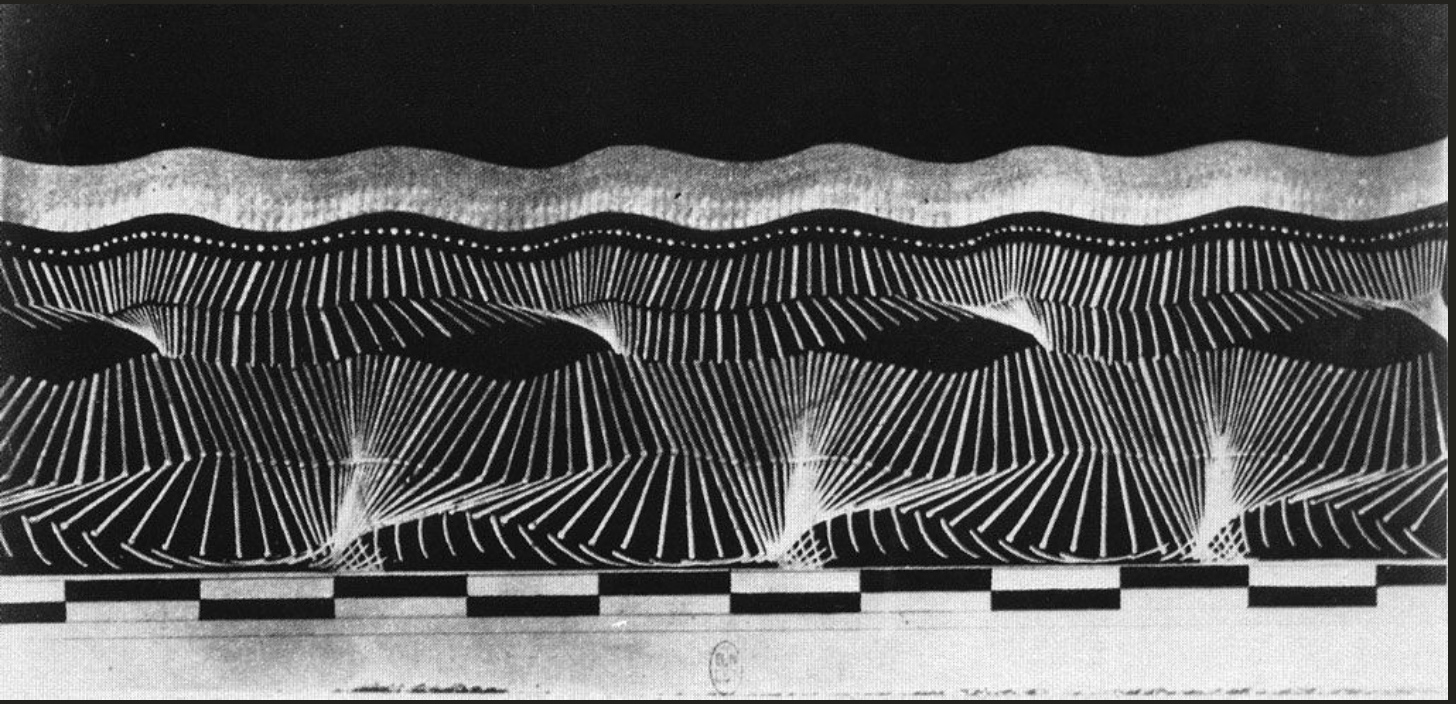
**Trevor Paglen**
*Singleton/SBW ASS-R1 and Three Unidentified Spacecrafts*
2012

**Liz Deschenes**
*Untitled 2 (8.5)*
*numbers 5-10*
2018

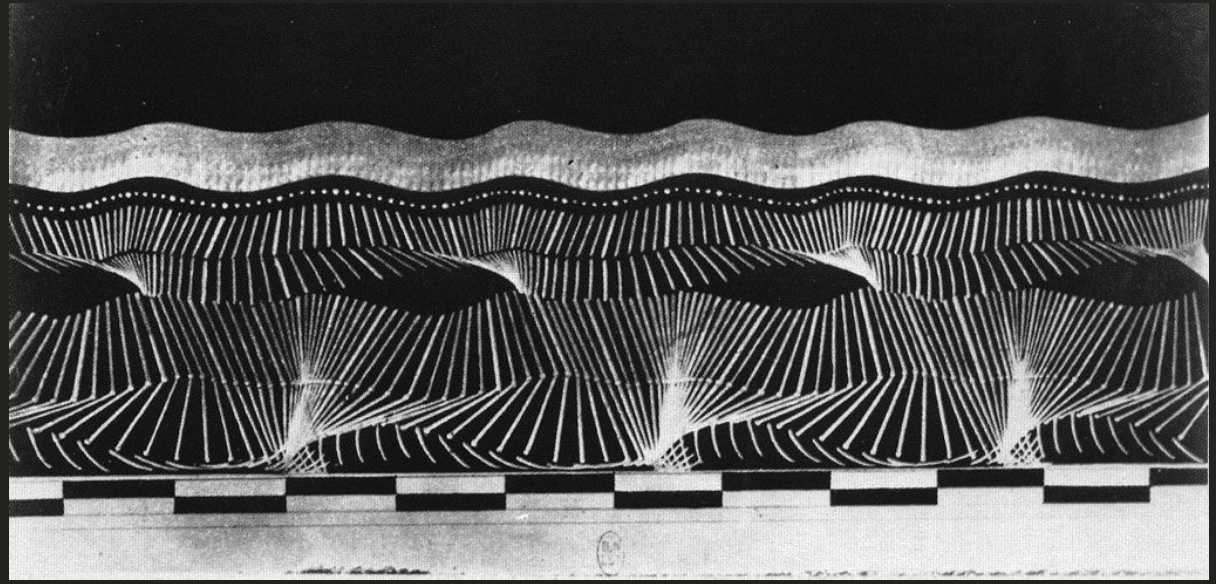
# photographing the invisible



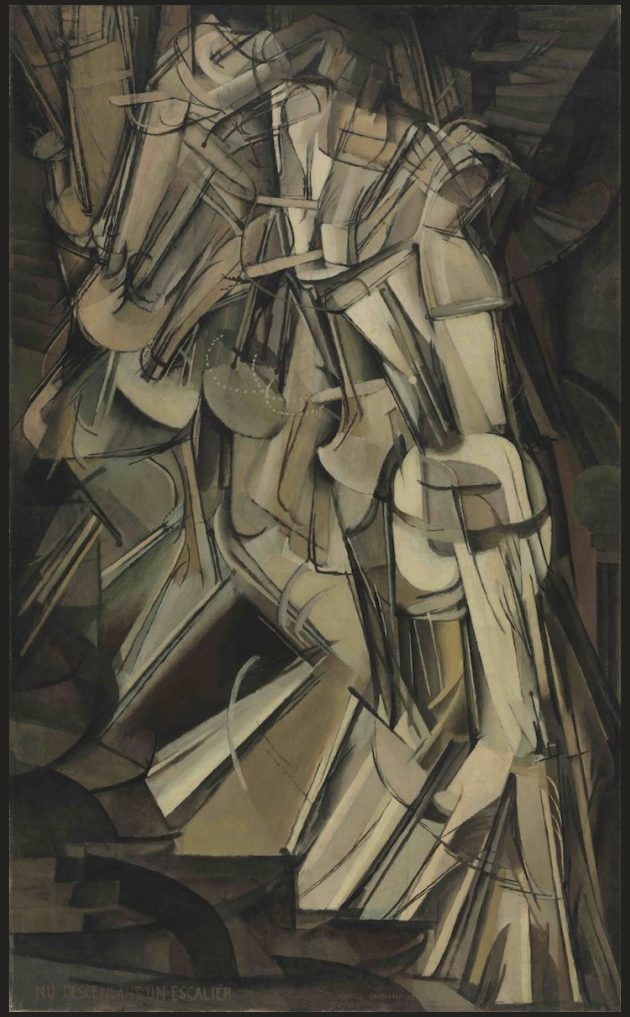
**Étienne-Jules Marey**
*Man Walking*
*1882*



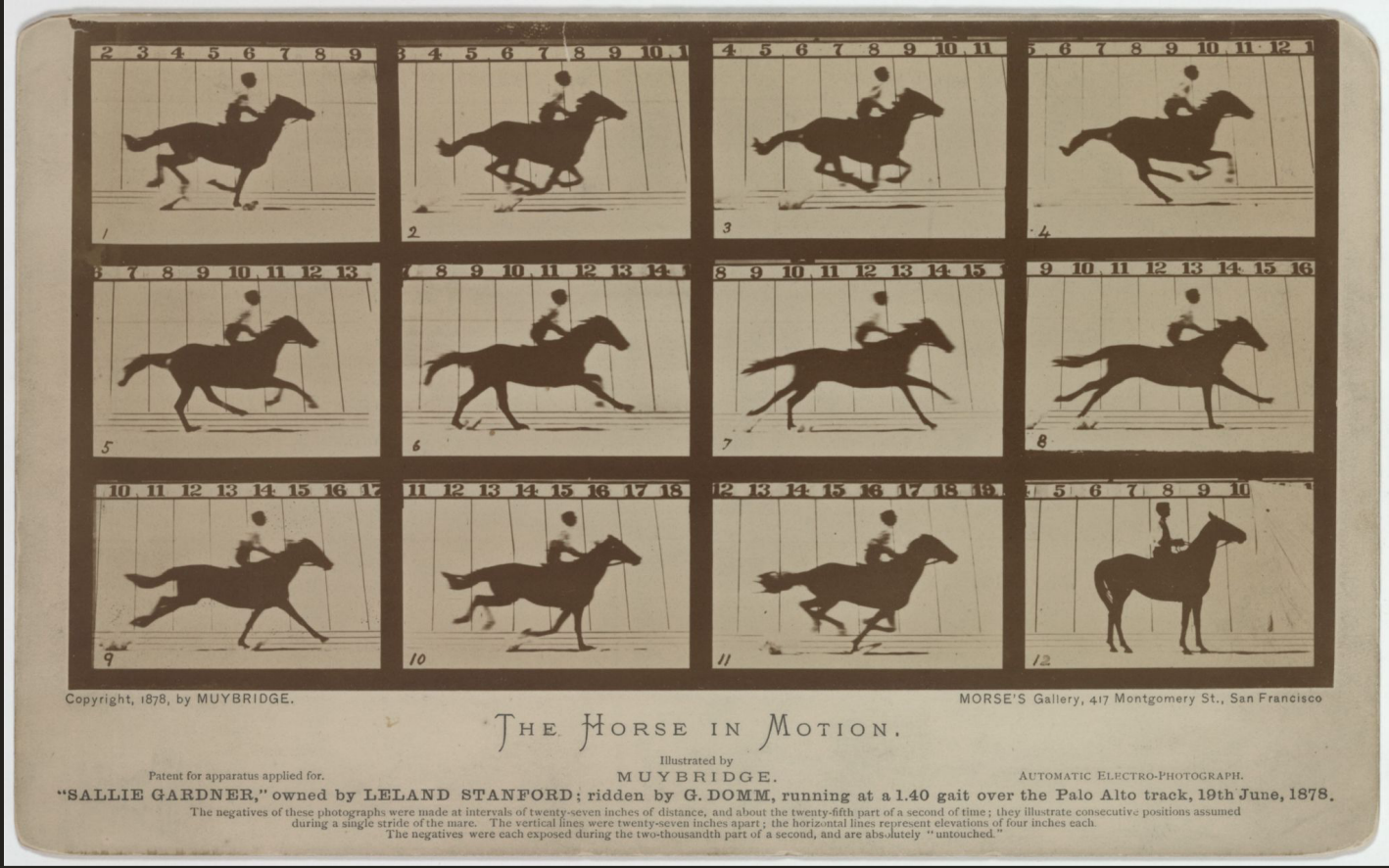
**Étienne-Jules Marey**
*Joinville Soldier Walking*
1883



**Étienne-Jules Marey**
*Joinville Soldier Walking*
1883

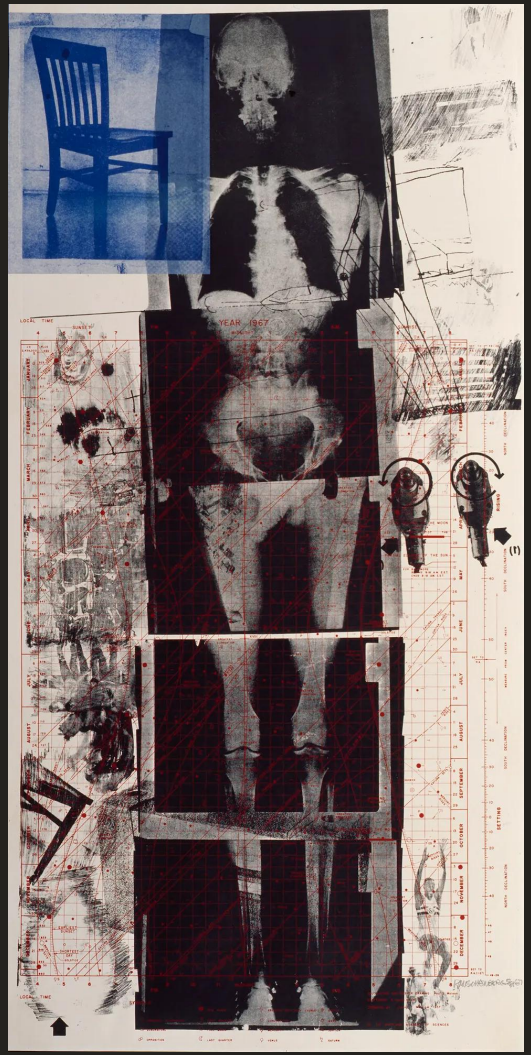



**Marcel Duchamp**
*Nude Descending a Staircase*
1912




**Eadweard Muybridge**
*The Horse in Motion*
1878

**William Rontgen**
*Hand with Rings*
1886




**Robert Rauschenberg**
*Booster*
1967

# key points

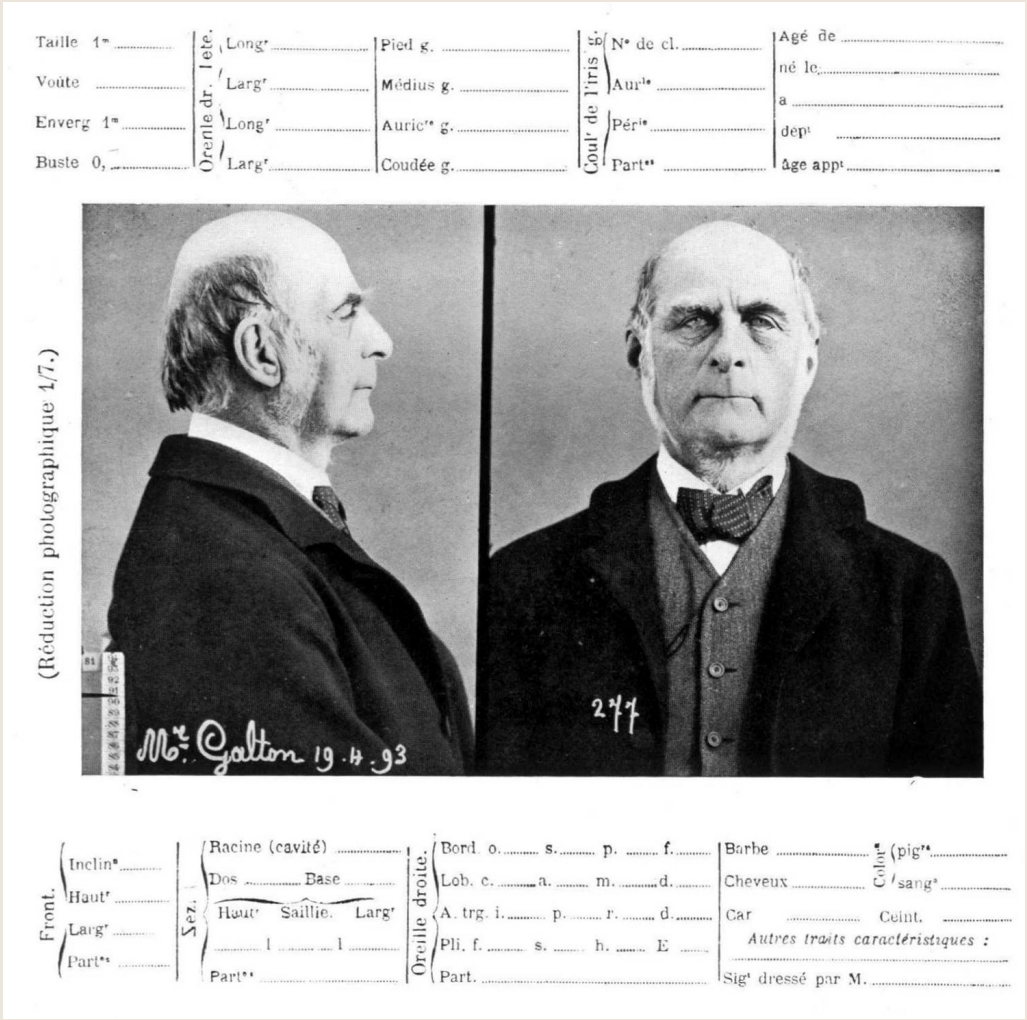
- cameras enabled observations and circulation of things we could not otherwise see
- as photography pushed beyond the visible,  it changed how we see and imagine the world

# key points

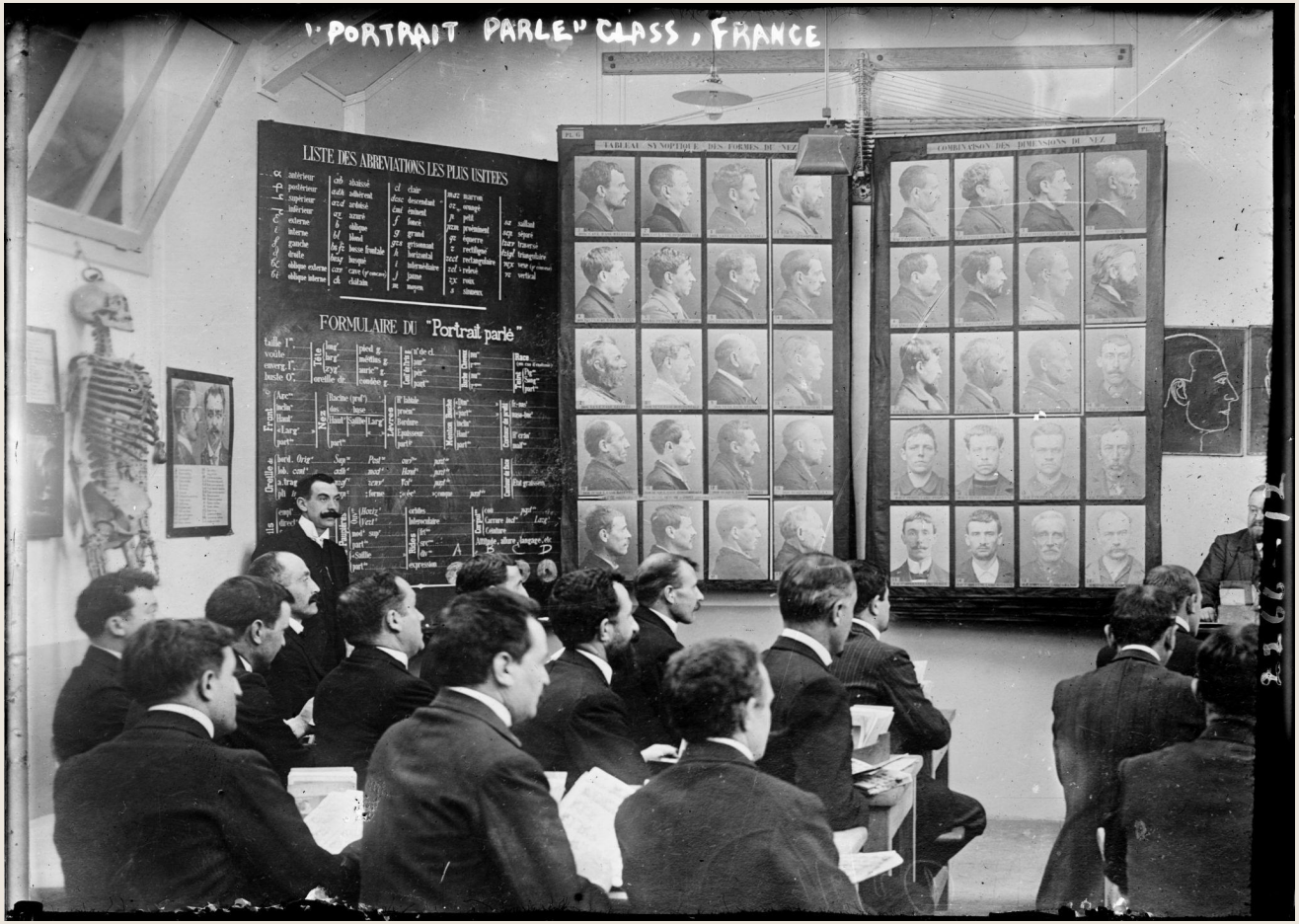
- from a very early point, photographs and knowledge generation were linked
- it was seen as a scientific instrument, but not immediately as art

# section iii.

*images as instruments of the State*



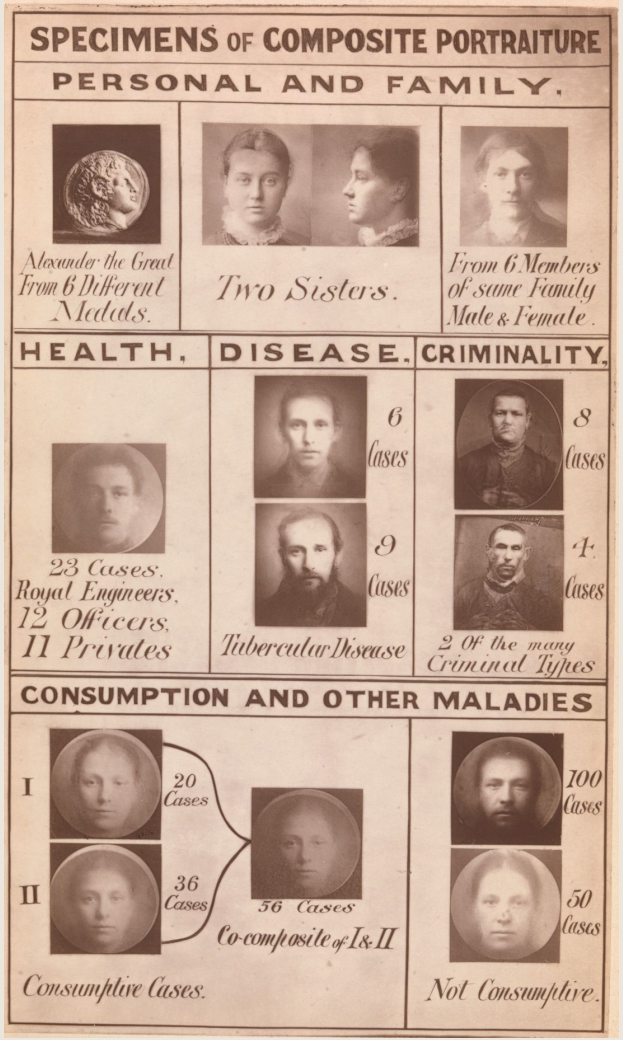

**Alphonse Bertillon**
*Mugshot and Record of Francis Galton*
1893




**Class on the Bertillon System, France**
1911

**“The central artifact of this system is not the camera but the filing cabinet”**

- Allen Sekula, “The Body and the Archive”




**Francis Galton**
*Inquiries into Human Faculty and Its Development*
1883

# CONSUMPTION AND OTHER MALADIES

I

20 Cases

II

36 Cases

56 Cases

Co-composite of I & II

Consumptive Cases.

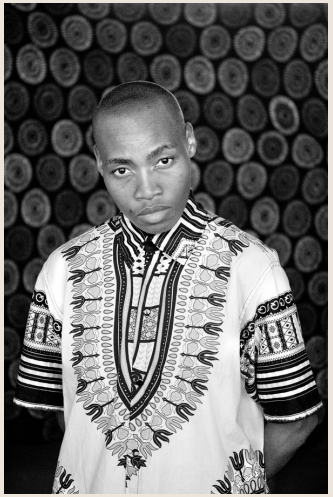
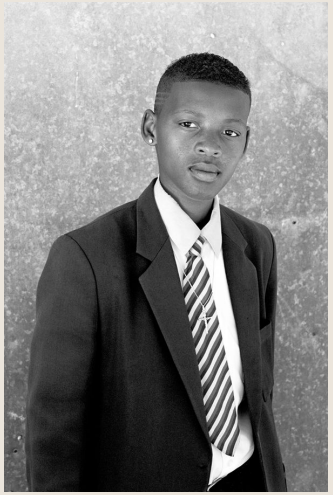
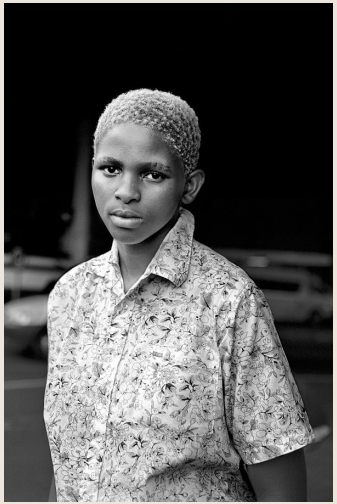
100 Cases

50 Cases

Not Consumptive.

artists working with and against this history

**Taryn Simon**
*A Living Man Declared Dead and Other Chapters I – XVIII*
2011

**Zanele Muholi**
*Faces and Phases*
2006–ongoing

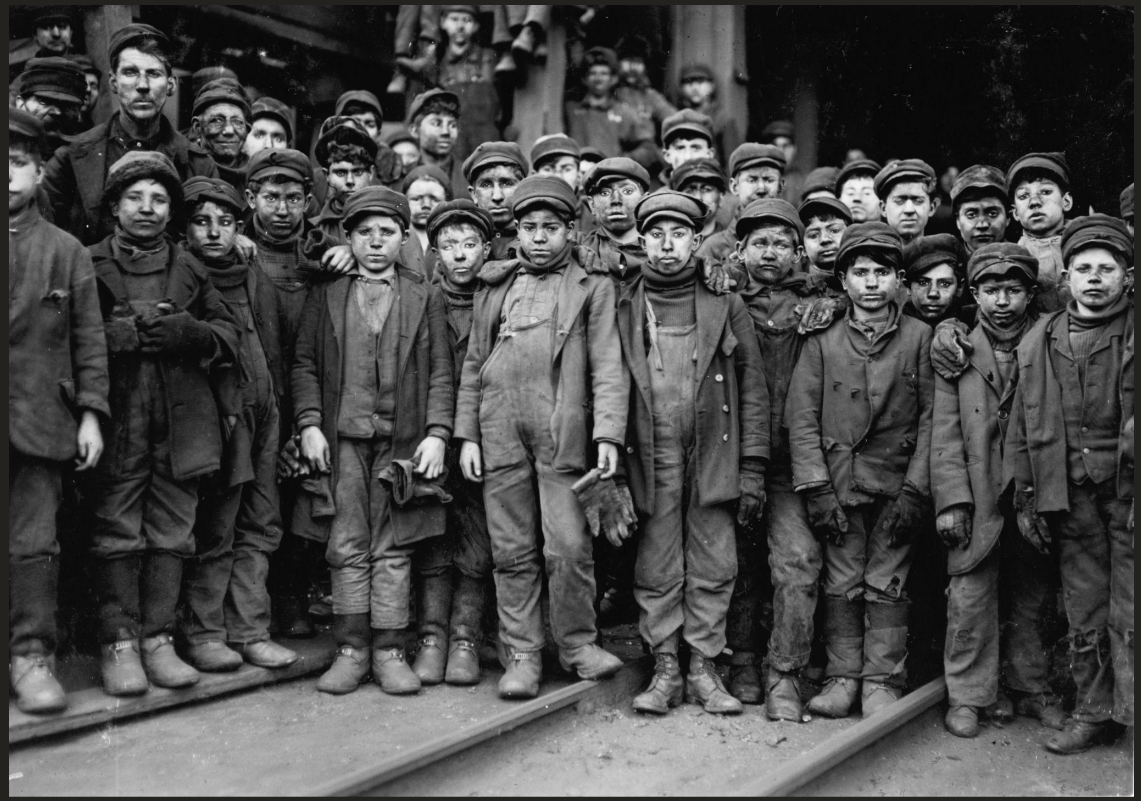
# key points

- a new kind of evidence, no longer just the trace
- relies on text, data, measurement, and archives
- uses photography as a tool to both generate knowledge and exercise control

# section iv.

*documentary and manipulation*

**Jacob Riis**
*"Nomads of the Street", Street children in their sleeping quarters, New York*
1890s



**Lewis Hine**
*Breaker boys working in Ewen Breaker of Pennsylvania Coal Co. South Pittston, Pennsylvania.*
1911

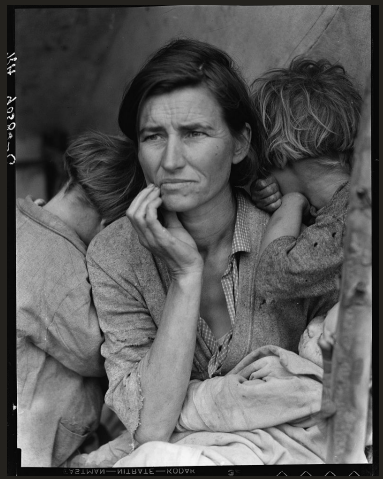
**Lewis Hine**

*Sadie Pfeifer, 48 inches high, has worked half a year. One of the many small children at work in Lancaster Cotton Mills*

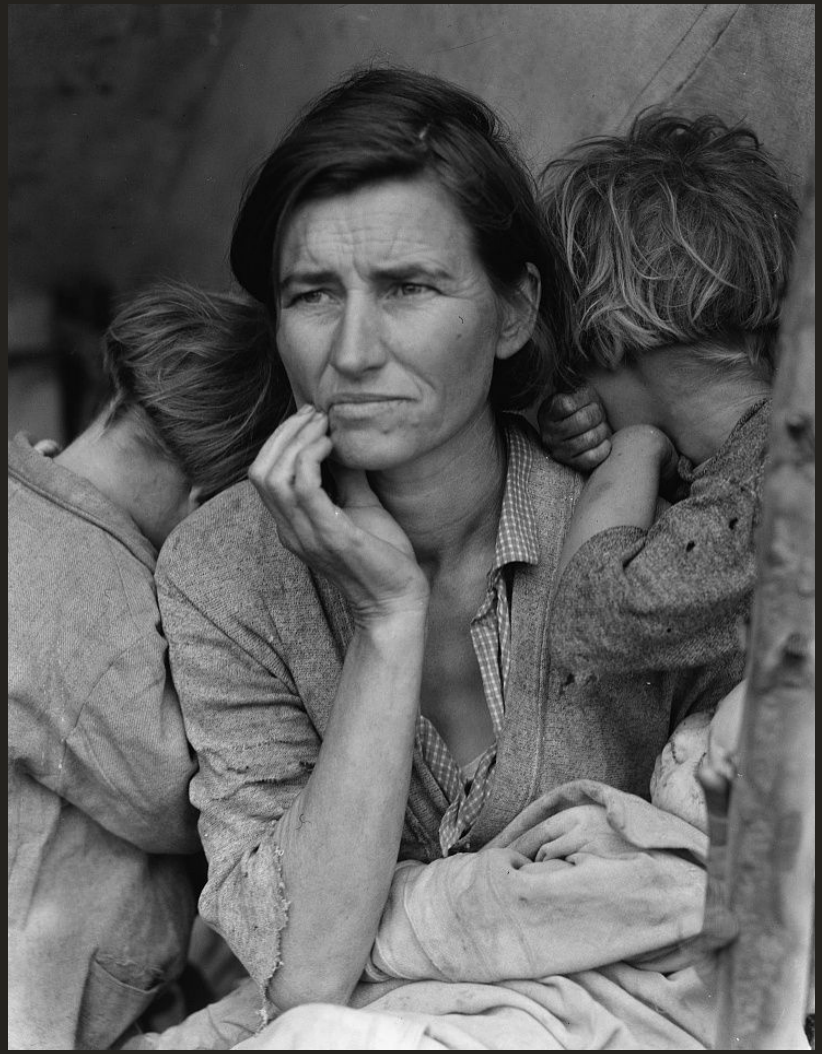
1908

**In contrast to the pure sensationalism of much of the journalistic attention to working-class, immigrant, and slum life, the meliorism of Riis, Lewis Hine, and others involved in social-work propagandizing argued, through the presentation of images combined with other forms of discourse, for the rectification of wrongs. It did not perceive those wrongs as fundamental to the social system that tolerated them — the assumption that they were tolerated rather than *bred* marks a basic fallacy of social work.**

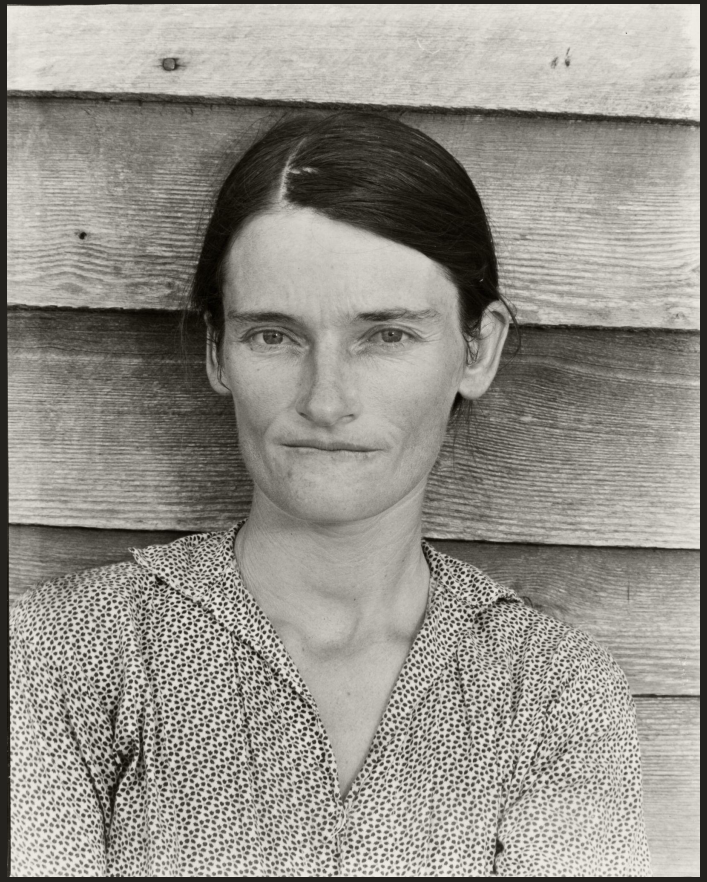
Martha Rosler, “In, around, and afterthoughts (on documentary photography),” 1981

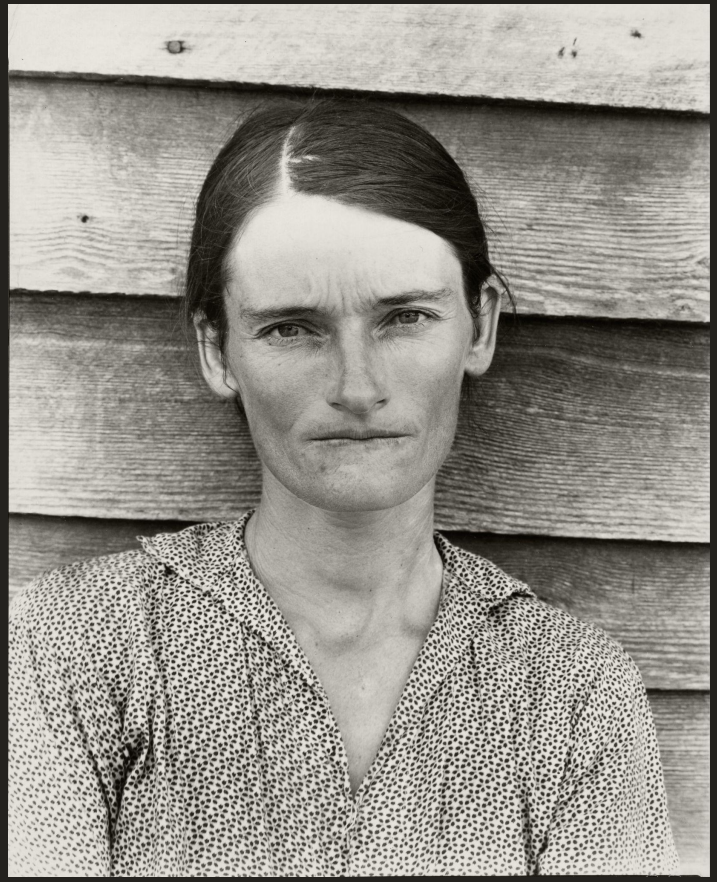


**Dorothea Lange**
*Migrant Mother*
(all frames)
1936



**Dorothea Lange**
*Migrant Mother*
1936





**Walker Evans**
*Allie Mae Burroughs*
1936

**Walker Evans**
*Corner of Kitchen* and *Farmer's Kitchen*
1936

**Walker Evans**
*Allie Mae Burroughs*
1936

**…rarely is a photograph's subject neutral or unmarked to begin with…In part, this derives from the fact that photography, like all camera-made images such as film and video, effaces the marks of its making (and maker) at the click of a shutter.**

Abigail Solomon-Godeau, “Who Is Speaking Thus? Some Questions about Documentary Photography,” 1991

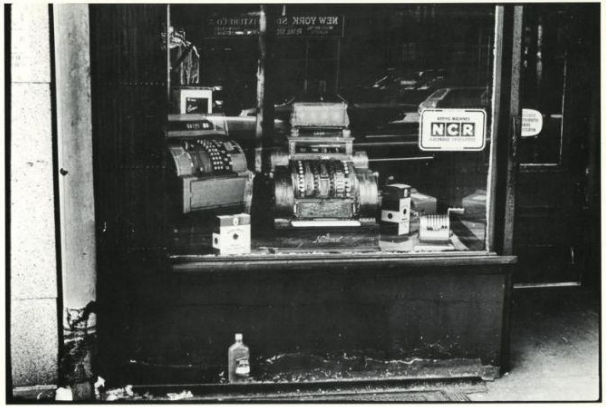
**A photograph appears to be self-generated — as though it had created itself. We know the photographer had to have been on the scene — indeed, this serves as a further guarantee of the image's truth — but the photographer is manifestly absent from the field of the image. Instead, we are there; we are seeing what the photographer saw at the moment of exposure.**

Abigail Solomon-Godeau, “Who Is Speaking Thus? Some Questions about Documentary Photography,” 1991

**This structural congruence of point of view (the eye of the photographer, the eye of the camera, and the spectator's eye) confers on the photograph a quality of pure, but delusory, presentness. A photograph, as Victor Burgin once remarked, is an offer that cannot be refused.**

Abigail Solomon-Godeau, “Who Is Speaking Thus? Some Questions about Documentary Photography,” 1991

hard drinker
funnel
drinkitite
emperor
bingo boy, bingo mort
dipsomaniac




dead soldiers

dead marines

stewed
boiled
potted
corned
pickled
preserved
canned
fried to the hat

**Martha Rosler**
*The Bowery in Two Inadequate Descriptive Systems*
1974-75

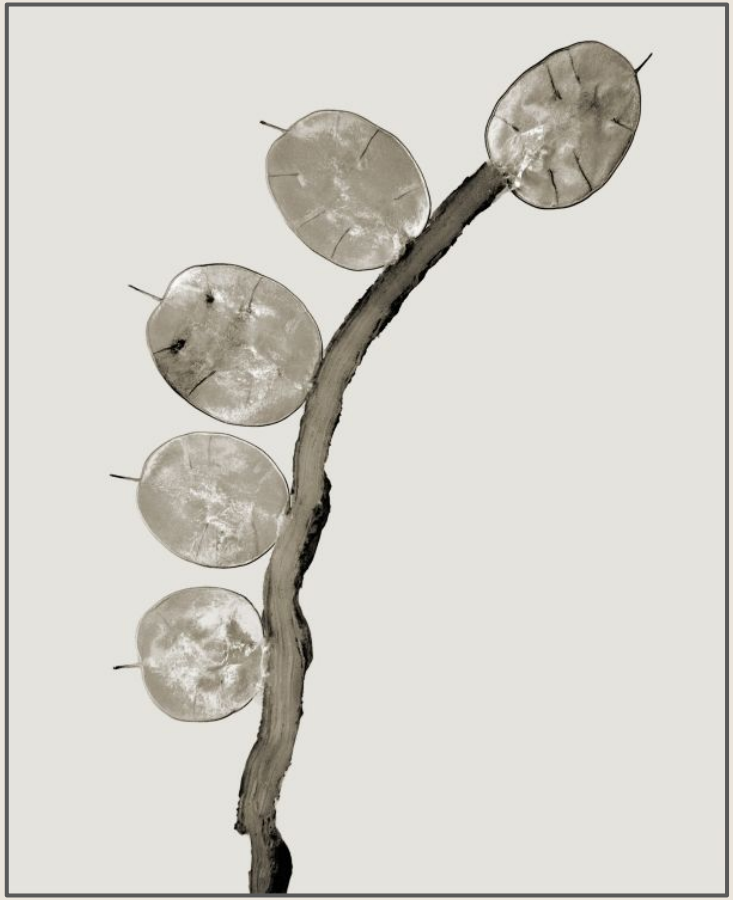
**Philip-Lorca diCorcia**
*Major Tom, Kansas City - $20,*
from *Hustlers*
1990

# key points

- the term “documentary” was invented and championed — it’s historical, not ontological
- involved manipulation, editing, and selection that advanced an invisible argument or position
- while it proposed to ameliorate societal ills, it was funded by the government and the wealthy

# section v.

*images beyond referents*



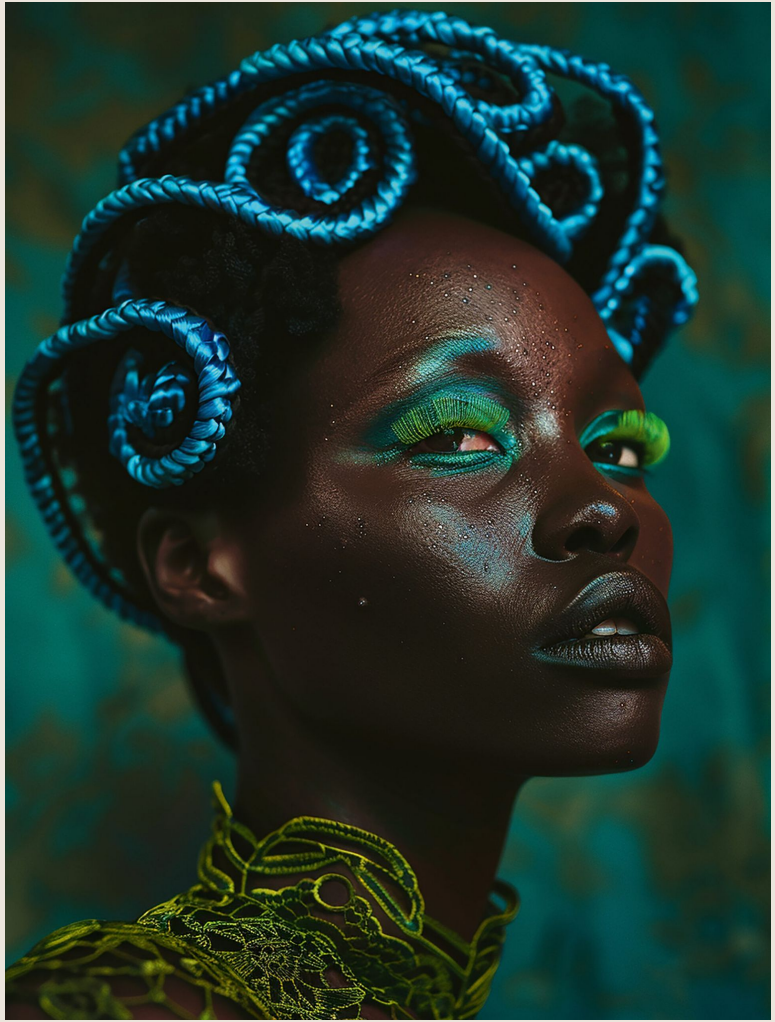
*'Himenea flaccida'*

*'Fungus mungus'*

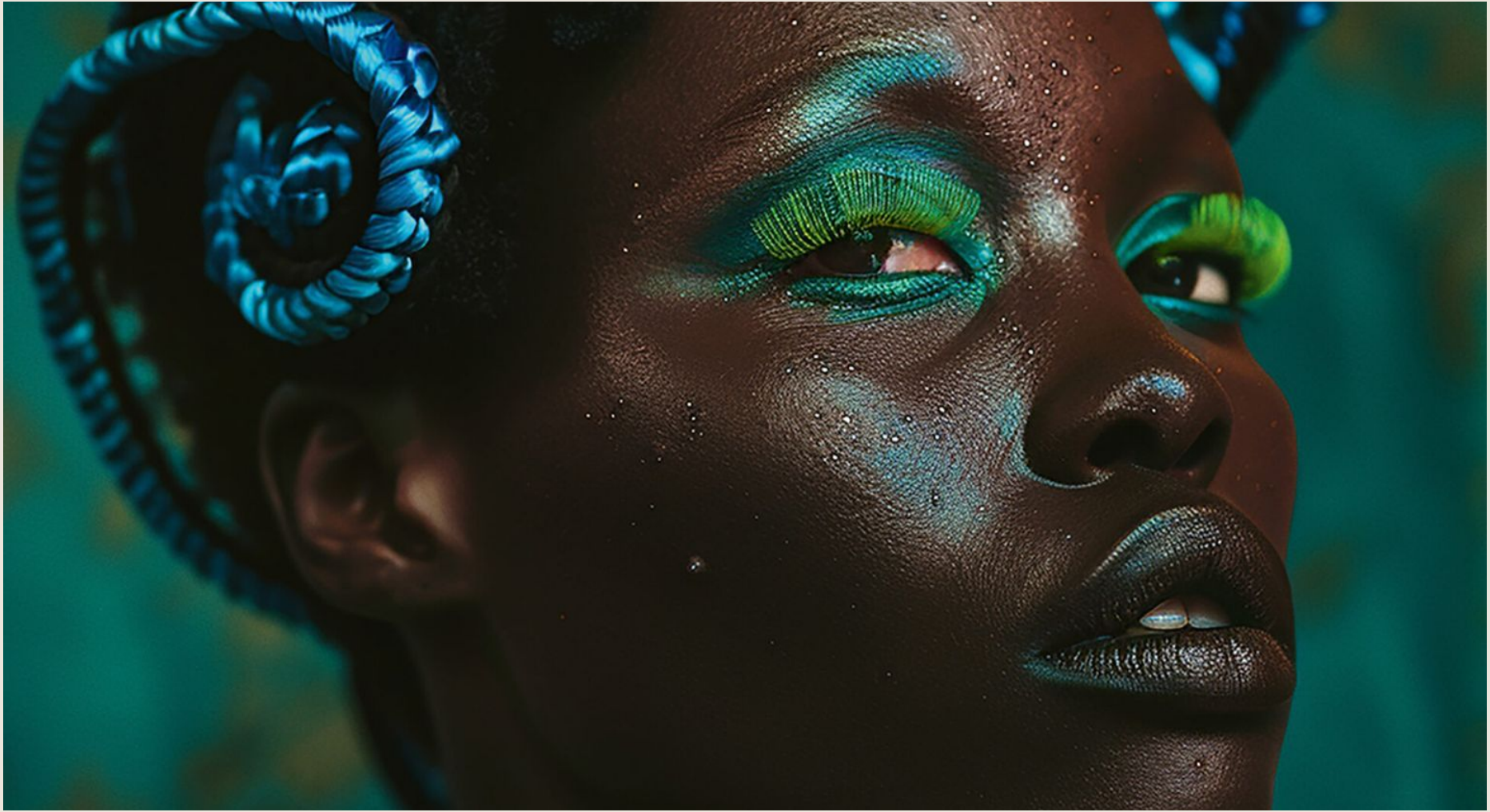
**Joan Fontcuberta**
*Herbarium*
1983

aperture
Image Worlds to Come
Photography & AI
No. 257
Winter 2024

**Boris Eldagsen/ DALLE2**
*The Electrician*, from the series *PSEUDOMNESIA*
2022



**Minne Atairu**
from the series
*Cornrow Studies*
2024



**Should photography's relationship to physical existence become suddenly tenuous, its vocabulary would be transformed and its system of representation would have to be reconsidered.**

\- Fred Ritchin, *In Our Own Image*, 1990

# key points

- generated images change the ontology of photography
- still developing: theories, histories, and all risks/opportunities are not yet known